

are more into using their computers for general purposes, with a little bit of gaming thrown in. We look at what the cards had to offer to us.

Their Features

Half the cards we received were of the XFX brand, and they offered a versatile range from the absolute minimum in video memory to the maximum possible available in this category. Only two out of the eight cards featured dual-monitor connectors. On the bright side, all the cards featured video-out, which can be used to connect a TV. And why would you connect a TV to your computer? Try watching a DivX movie on a TV, and you probably wouldn't ask that again.

The XFX Personal Cinema was the only card in this category to offer a TV Tuner chip on-board. This definitely gave it a plus, since you need not install a separate TV Tuner card for watching TV on your computer. However, that does not explain the Rs 11,000 price tag, since you can easily get a 9600XT at that price. That was about all that the cards in this category had to offer. The rest of the cards were all just vanilla, and expectedly so, since they are not priced high.

Their Performance

The performance of the cards across the board ranged from mediocre to excellent, given the price these cards retail at. The MSI and the XFX reigned in this category. Surprisingly, the XFX GeForce FX 5200 64 MB posted excellent results compared to most 128 MB cards, and in fact, beat both the models from XFX itself. The MSI TD-128 FX 5200 was another good performing card in this category.

The Gigabyte did relatively well, but was not good enough to get ahead of the above three cards. The 5200s by themselves are crippled, going by the number of pipelines and core and memory speeds.

Most users will have to make do playing at a resolution of 800 x 600 using these cards.

We ran *Half-Life 2* and *Doom 3* as Tier 1 tests (See box "How We Tested and Decided the Award Winners" on page 62 for details on Tier 1 and Tier 2 tests) on these cards, because these are the latest games available—and if the cards we

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tested are not able to play them even at low resolutions, they may not be worth investing in at all. *Doom 3* is a real resource-hogger. All the cards suffered and posted unplayable frame-rates at 800 x 600, but were okay at 640 x 480 (although 21 frames is still very jerky for playing a game), giving reasonable frame-rates. With *Half-Life 2*, the cards were more than happy and posted good frame-rates, with the XFX 64 MB giving 35 fps at 1,024 x 768. (These frame-rates were posted after the DX9 fix was applied for the cards in the game. See Box "OEM Deals and How They Affect Your Gaming Experience" on page 78)

A similar scenario was observed with *Far Cry*, with the settings at Medium in the game. The frame-rates at 800 x 600 were enough for any user to play the game smoothly. The XFX FX 5200 128 MB (non-TV Tuner) card was disappointing, and gave some of the most rock-bottom frame-rates amongst the whole lot. In our performance tests, the best performers were the MSI and the XFX, with the Gigabyte following closely.

First-time entrant PNY gave good frame-rates, but could not hold its own against the above-mentioned cards.

Overall, in the budget category, the cards gave us the expected results, and we filtered out the best amongst them to arrive at the winners.

The Winners Are...

From the results of the performance tests, it is clear that the winners were going to be from the XFX stables, given the frame-rates that they posted in each game. Agreed, the frame-rates in *Doom 3* were nothing to write home about, but it does prove a point: if you want to play games like *Doom 3*, an FX 5200 is not the card for it—and you will definitely need to spend some more in the graphics department. On the

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need to upgrade your motherboard and CPU as well!

Another telling factor is that the upcoming Microsoft OS, code-named Windows Longhorn, will need a DirectX 9-compliant video card, if you wish to appreciate its interface in all its glory. It has lots of eye candy which can only be experienced through a DX 9 card.

BUDGET VIDEO CARDS

The budget segment consisted of eight cards that had the same chipset, which was the FX 5200 from nVidia. This category was specifically created for users who

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